

# Build Muscle & Burn Fat at the Same Time (No BS)

Channel: Brandon Carter · Published: Oct 09, 2026 · Watch: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=k66DrJraGXM> Source: full transcript

## Executive Summary

Brandon Carter argues that traditional bulking/cutting cycles fail natural lifters. His "micro cut / micro bulk" method keeps you lean year-round while steadily building muscle through aggressive calorie swings, high protein, and high-frequency full-body training.

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## Why Simultaneous Fat Loss & Muscle Gain Is Hard 0:41

- Most people are told to do a "recomp" — a small calorie deficit while continuing to lift
  - Carter says recomp only reliably works for brand-new lifters in their first year of serious training
  - After that first year, it becomes very difficult
- Traditional bodybuilder-style bulking and cutting is ineffective for natural (or near-natural) athletes
  - Pro bodybuilders spend ~half the year bulking (looking fat and ugly by their own admission) and ~half cutting just to look good on one competition day
  - They can do this because they use large amounts of PEDs (growth hormone, supraphysiological testosterone, etc.) which let them build far more muscle while bulking AND retain far more muscle while cutting
  - A natural lifter who copies this protocol ends up spending most of the year looking bad for minimal net muscle gain
- Carter discloses he is on TRT (testosterone replacement therapy), keeping levels around 900 ng/dL — within normal range but at the high end
  - At age 20 his natural level was 1,200–1,400; TRT at 45 still leaves him below his youthful peak

- He distinguishes medical TRT from supraphysiological steroid use

## **The Micro Cut / Micro Bulk Framework 1:23**

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- The core idea: instead of months-long bulk/cut phases, alternate short micro cuts and micro bulks, never letting body fat get high
- Two body-fat "lines" define the playing field:
  - **~10% body fat** — the "lean/ripped" line; goal is to stay at or below this
  - ~20% body fat — the "danger zone" where Carter says you look visibly bad and hormones are compromised
- The cycle:
  - Start with a cut phase (first phase may be long if you're currently over-fat)
  - Cut down to ~10% or your personal lean target
  - Switch to a bulk phase — but stop bulking the moment abs definition begins to fade and you feel you'd be uncomfortable taking your shirt off
  - Immediately return to a micro cut
  - Repeat indefinitely
- Typical phase lengths once you're lean:
  - Micro bulk: 2–4 weeks
  - Micro cut: often only 2 weeks (sometimes less, because you never let fat accumulate much)
- The original concept comes from Bill Phillips (editor of *Muscle Media* magazine, founder of EAS Sports Nutrition — which introduced creatine to market) who used 2-week alternating phases; Carter refined it based on 30+ years of client experience to be flexible in duration
- Carter has run this protocol for 30+ consecutive years, which is why he appears lean in every YouTube video

The micro cut / micro bulk approach achieves the same net result as a recomp — muscle gained, fat lost — over the same timeframe, but without ever becoming visibly fat.

## **Why You Must Cut First (Hormonal Argument) 1:21**

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- Once body fat exceeds ~15%, two major hormonal problems emerge:
  - **Insulin sensitivity drops** → nutrient partitioning worsens → calories are stored as fat rather than used to build muscle
  - **Testosterone declines** → fat cells aromatize testosterone, disrupting the hormonal balance
- Consequence: bulking at high body fat produces far more fat gain and far less muscle gain than bulking from a lean state
- Post-cut bulking creates the opposite, ideal condition:
  - Insulin sensitivity is very high — muscles are primed to absorb nutrients

- Bodybuilders and physique competitors universally report their fastest muscle growth immediately after a competition cut, precisely because of this elevated insulin sensitivity
- Therefore, Carter strongly advises against the common advice to "bulk first" for skinny-fat people — they should cut first, always

## **Micro Cut Nutrition Protocol 13:16**

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- **Calorie target during a cut:** bodyweight (in lbs) × 10 = daily calories
  - Example: 200 lb person eats 2,000 kcal/day
- Carter rejects the popular "500-calorie deficit" advice for several reasons:
  - It is trivially easy to accidentally erase a 500-calorie deficit through:
    - Condiment/sauce calories (example: 50g of sugar-free honey mustard sauce = 200+ kcal)
    - FDA food label inaccuracy — labels are legally allowed to be off by 20% in either direction
    - Miscalculated liquids and unmeasured additions
  - "Fat loss is not something that should be sustainable. Fat loss means you're in a calorie deficit — by definition a mild form of starvation. Why would you want to sustain starvation?"
  - Get lean as fast as possible, then maintain; don't drag out the deficit
- **Protein target (cut AND bulk):** 1 gram per pound of bodyweight, always
  - Example: 200 lb person eats at least 200 g protein/day (Carter personally eats 250–300 g at ~195 lbs)
  - Rationale for the higher-than-minimum target:
    - Label inaccuracy of 20% means you may be getting less protein than you think
    - No proven downside to extra protein; Carter's blood work is consistently normal
    - Protein has a powerful thermogenic effect (thermic effect of food):

| Macronutrient  | Calories burned digesting it |
|----------------|------------------------------|
| Fat            | 0–3%                         |
| Carbohydrate   | 10–15%                       |
| <b>Protein</b> | <b>20–30%</b>                |

- Protein's 20–30% thermic effect is "like a cash-back card" — you consume the calories but immediately get a significant portion refunded as heat
- Protein is also the only macronutrient that directly preserves muscle mass during a deficit
- **Tracking rules:**
  - Track everything including sauces, dressings, and beverages
  - Drink no calorie-containing beverages
  - Eating the same foods daily makes hitting targets far easier
  - Weigh yourself every day; take a weekly average; if weight isn't dropping, either tracking is wrong or calories need to drop further

- Tool used: **Claw app** (previously used MyFitnessPal for 15 years)
  - Claw allows photo-based calorie estimation when a food scale isn't available (e.g., courtside at a basketball game) — less precise than weighing, but far better than guessing
  - Carter will link his Claw calorie-tracking prompts for free in the description

## **Training During the Cut: Heavy Lifting & Full-Body Workouts 20:36**

- The goal of training during a cut is to **preserve muscle**, not to use weights as cardio
- Common mistake: turning weight sessions into circuit training with 30–40 reps — Carter says don't do this
- During cuts Carter lifts his heaviest weights, dropping reps to 6–8 per set
  - Signals to the body that muscle is needed even in a calorie deficit, preventing catabolism
- **Full-body workouts are strongly preferred** over body-part splits
  - Protein synthesis (muscle-building signal) lasts only ~48 hours after resistance training
  - A bro-split chest day trains chest once a week → 5 days of potential growth signal are wasted
  - 4 full-body sessions/week keeps protein synthesis continuously elevated for every muscle group
- Workout structure Carter uses:
  - 1–2 exercises per body part
  - 2–3 sets each
  - Superset opposing muscle groups with no rest between paired exercises (e.g., bench press → bent-over row; incline bench press → chin-ups; bicep curl → tricep extension)
  - Rest between supersets: ~60 seconds (measured with Apple Watch timer, called out verbally)
  - Target: workout under 60 minutes total
- Isolation exercises used only for arms (bicep curls, tricep extensions) because true compound movements are harder to program for those muscles
- If someone prefers a split, Carter accepts push/pull/legs or upper/lower as reasonable alternatives; "bro splits" (one muscle group per day) are not recommended for natural lifters

## **Full-Body vs. Bro-Split: The Volume Math 22:40**

- Concrete annual volume comparison (chest example):

| Approach                                            | Sets per session | Sessions/week | Weekly sets | Annual sets  |
|-----------------------------------------------------|------------------|---------------|-------------|--------------|
| Bro split (chest day, 4 exercises × 3 sets)         | 12               | 1             | 12          | ~624         |
| Full-body (2 chest exercises × 4 sets × 4 sessions) | 8                | 4             | 32          | <b>1,664</b> |

- Full-body athlete does **~2.67× more total chest sets per year**
- Compounded by exercise quality: bro-split lifters typically mix 2 compound + 2 isolation exercises; Carter does only compound movements

- **Compound (multi-joint) moves** (e.g., bench press) recruit more muscle and drive more hypertrophy
- **Isolation (single-joint) moves** (e.g., chest fly) are less effective for mass
- Carter's sets are therefore roughly twice as productive per set as well
- Historical note: bro-splits were designed by and for steroid users, whose prolonged protein synthesis made hammering one muscle group per session worthwhile; natural lifters should not follow this template

## **Splitting Sessions for Maximum Intensity 26:11**

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- Workout intensity degrades over time regardless of fitness level — the first half of any session is always more intense than the second
  - Example: professional boxers are exhausted and less powerful in later rounds despite elite conditioning
- **Solution: split one long session into two shorter sessions**
  - Two 30-minute sessions = "two first halves" → both are maximally intense
  - This is a technique Carter learned from Wall Street friends in New York who trained 30 min before work and 30 min after work
  - Carter himself did this commuting from Queens, stopping at Crunch on 34th Street before and after his office day
- Carter now splits even further: three 20-minute sessions per day using his condo gym
- Benefits:
  - Higher intensity per set
  - Shorter rest periods needed (more energy available)
  - Total time spent is the same or less
- Commuters can still do 30 min morning + 30 min evening without needing a home gym

## **Micro Bulk Nutrition Protocol 27:15**

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- **Calorie target during a bulk:**  $\text{bodyweight (in lbs)} \times 20 = \text{daily calories}$ 
  - Example: 200 lb person eats at least 4,000 kcal/day
  - "More is fine, but at least 4,000" for a 200 lb person
- **Protein stays identical:** 1 g per pound of bodyweight, every phase
- Summary table:

| Phase      | Calorie formula        | Protein    |
|------------|------------------------|------------|
| Micro Cut  | $\text{lbs} \times 10$ | 1 g per lb |
| Micro Bulk | $\text{lbs} \times 20$ | 1 g per lb |

- Stop bulking cue: when abs definition starts to blur and you feel uncomfortable shirtless — no need to measure body fat percentage precisely
- This cycle can be run indefinitely; Carter ran it for 20+ consecutive years



## Tracking Tools & Maintenance Phase 29:19

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- After 20+ years of micro cut / micro bulk, Carter shifted in 2026 to a maintenance approach
  - Maintenance calories: ~3,000 kcal/day
  - He eats slightly under 3,000, never over
  - Protein remains 250–300 g/day at ~195 lbs
- Also now using peptides (mentioned briefly; separate videos cover specifics)
- Key tracking tools mentioned:
  - **Claw app** — current primary tracker; supports photo-based logging
  - **MyFitnessPal** — used for 15 years prior
  - **Apple Watch** — used to set 60-second rest timers during workouts
- Weigh-in protocol: daily weigh-ins, weekly average used to assess progress
  - If weekly average isn't dropping during a cut, assume a tracking error before reducing calories
- Closing reminder: the entire protocol requires consistent food tracking — without it, "you are being lazy and will not understand anything"